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01/18/2026
Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Committee
UCLA

Dear Colleagues,

It is my pleasure to nominate Tucker Allen for UCLA's Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. I have worked with Tucker for roughly five years as his research advisor, and I observed his teaching directly while he served as my teaching assistant this past fall for graduate physical chemistry, Chem 223A. I also regularly see him teach in our research group through presentations, group meetings, and mentoring. Tucker is the complete package as an educator: he has deep command of difficult material, he communicates with unusual clarity, and he consistently brings students along with him rather than leaving them behind.

Chem 223A is not an easy course to teach well. Many students can follow lecture but still struggle when asked to apply ideas independently. Tucker has a rare ability to translate abstract statistical mechanics into reasoning steps students can actually use. He does not just solve problems; he teaches students how to start and how to organize their thinking. His discussions were consistently well prepared and aimed at the points where students were stuck. Student feedback captured this precisely: Tucker "did a great job of identifying concepts that the class was struggling to understand" and "organizing the discussion to aid these problems."

Most TAs can run a discussion section, far fewer can lead course design that consistently pulls understanding out of students. Tucker did. He helped us keep the course centered around in-person work: quizzes done in person, computational activities completed during class, and a final project written during class time with feedback as it evolved. The discussion board Tucker managed was not cosmetic; it became a central mechanism for student questions and peer explanation, with Tucker actively moderating and steering. The result was a course that demanded real thinking while still supporting students through it.

What makes Tucker especially deserving of this award is that the same strengths show up across years and course types. In first-year labs, one student wrote, "Give this man a promotion … Tucker is literally the best." In upper-division thermodynamics, students say that his tutorial and discussion "really clarify the class content tremendously," especially when lecture alone left them lost. At the graduate level, students describe Tucker as going "above and beyond," explaining material "in many different ways," and ensuring that even students who were

struggling could “keep up … and succeed.” These are not generic compliments; they point to a sustained pattern of impact.

In my experience, TAs who combine this level of technical mastery with genuine teaching skill are rare. Tucker’s teaching is consistently at an instructor level. I recommend him **extremely strongly** for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Sincerely yours,



Daniel Neuhauser
Professor of Theoretical Chemistry
Department of Chemistry and Biochemistry, UCLA

Self-Statement

I teach chemistry with students learning on the front stage. My job is to turn effort into intuition: I design discussions and tutorials so students attempt early, ask questions freely, and rehearse the first moves of problem solving often enough that they can carry the learning on their own.

My teaching spans first-year instructional labs, upper-division thermodynamics, and graduate physical chemistry for advanced undergraduates and PhD students. Across these settings, the same barriers show up: students hesitate to start because the opening steps feel unclear, and they read early confusion as a personal shortcoming. Through intentional and explicit instruction with enough structured practice, I have tried to make the daunting world of chemistry attainable to a wide variety of learners. This approach to teaching is reflected across student comments in Artifact #1.

My first official TA appointment was 14BL, after serving as an undergraduate Learning Assistant in 14BL at UCLA. Lab is intimidating for first-year students for concrete reasons: safety risks, unfamiliar equipment, difficult pre-lab questions, and procedures that are hard to translate into action. I learned quickly that "read the procedure" is not instruction. The most effective methodology was building short, practical structure at the start of every session: a brief explanation of the chemistry (what we are trying to see and why it matters), followed by a hands-on demonstration of any new technique or equipment. During lab I circulate constantly, intervene early, promote inquisition, and celebrate small wins when students see expected results. Because lab practical exams can be high-stress, I make expectations explicit and provide practice aligned to the assessment. The final review notes I wrote for 14BL illustrate how I make preparation transparent (Artifact #4), and student feedback emphasizes that this level of support made a decisive difference (Artifact #1).

In 110A, students often can follow a lecture derivation, but cannot launch into unfamiliar homework problems independently, especially when lecture or textbook explanations feel incomplete. My response is guided practice built around decision-making. I build tutorial problem sets and worksheets that walk students through scientific thinking: choosing an approach, stating assumptions, checking whether an answer makes sense, and interpreting what the result means. I also use authentic data from published research in tutorial problems, so thermodynamics feels like a tool for extracting meaning from real numbers rather than a rite of passage. Tutorial Problem Set 5 is a representative example (Artifact #3). This approach scales: in Spring 2025 (110A), 49 of 66 students responded (74% response rate), and my overall TA rating was 8.39/9 (median 9) (Artifact #1).

In graduate physical chemistry, the "how do I start?" problem persists, but quieter: students may sit with confusion rather than interrupt. In discussion, I deliberately make question-asking informal, so students can ask mid-thought, backtrack, and test ideas without it feeling intimidating. I build real-time experimentation into learning through short computational simulations and activities. Additionally, to promote student inquisition and ownership of their learning, I use low-stakes quizzes where hints are provided so students do not freeze and turn in an empty page. Quiz 3 from the 123A/223A course illustrates this approach (Artifact #2).

Students in these courses describe the impact in concrete terms: help digesting difficult material and guidance on how to even begin the homework (Artifact #1).

In Fall 2025, I taught 223A alongside my PhD advisor, Daniel Neuhauser. We treated course design as a practical problem amid the widespread availability of AI tools: how do you ensure students are learning when tools exist that can generate polished work instantly? We shifted weight onto what cannot be outsourced, including reasoning out loud, revision, and work developed during class time. I ran a weekly discussion forum where students posted questions and responded to classmates; I moderated throughout the week, and I used the posts to guide what concepts needed to be revisited in the next discussion (Artifact #5).

My teaching is backed by preparation beyond required TA training: UCLA's Science Education minor trained me in lesson planning and objective-aligned assessment with middle/high school student teaching placements further strengthening my classroom management and facilitation skills. Last summer, my time as a teacher for Johns Hopkins Centered for Talented Youth (CTY) developed my ability to run inquiry-based, student-centered learning environments. Finally, my commitment to equity-based teaching is personal. I grew up seeing education as the way out of poverty. For me, equity is not lowering expectations; it is making hidden steps visible, reducing fear of failure, and giving students enough structured practice to become independent.

Statement of Teaching

Learning is one of the most human things we do. For this reason, I try to teach with empathy and understanding of where students are at. Chemistry is considered intimidating for students with its swaths of equations and abstract ideas, but the real point is deeper: these courses give students tools to explain the world and, eventually, to produce new knowledge in their own research. I teach with that goal in mind. I want students to build intuition, develop judgment, and learn how to begin when the path is not obvious. That requires a classroom where attempting is normal, questions are welcomed, and the focus stays on understanding rather than perfection.

My teaching is student-centered in a practical sense. I design around what students really do when they learn. They try, get stuck, ask, revise, and try again. So, I build frequent low-stakes opportunities to attempt early and often. Low stakes change behavior: students are more willing to risk being wrong, they ask questions sooner, and they show me what they do not understand, while there is still time to address it. I reinforce simple norms: no "dumb questions," confusion is expected, and mistakes are useful information for me as their instructor. Student feedback across labs, upper-division thermodynamics, and graduate physical chemistry is included in my teaching artifacts (Artifact #1).

A central part of my teaching is making the first moves in problem solving explicit. Most students who struggle are not struggling on the last line of a solution; they are stuck at the beginning. What is being asked? What approach should I try first? What assumptions am I making? What should I check? I treat those decisions as core teaching content. I structure section time around making those questions visible and repeatedly practiced, until students can answer them confidently on their own. Over time, students stop waiting for instructions and start building their own approach. The ability to approach new problems without panic is the outcome I care most about, because it produces students who are independent thinkers. These principles stay the same across courses, only the scaffolding changes with the context.

I think about equity in terms of what the course asks students to do, and what support is built in to help them do it. Students arrive with uneven preparation and very different comfort levels speaking up. That's true in both undergraduate and graduate courses, where prior math and science training can vary widely across schools and programs. My approach is to make expectations explicit early, including what background knowledge I am assuming, and then to give students structured ways to fill in gaps without stigma. That means targeted refreshers, optional review materials, and a classroom culture where asking questions is normal, not something reserved for the top students. This translates to designing classroom engagement so there are multiple low-pressure ways to attempt, ask, and revise. This makes learning possible for more students.

In first-year instructional labs, beginning with CHEM 14BL, readiness and confidence are teachable. Lab has safety risk, unfamiliar equipment, and procedures that are hard to translate into action. I begin with a short explanation of the chemistry and a demonstration of new techniques before students attempt them. During lab I circulate constantly and intervene early. I also make exam preparation explicit: students should not have to guess what competent work looks like. The review notes I provide show how I make expectations transparent and organize

practice around specific skills (Artifact #4), and student comments reflect that this kind of transparency can be the difference between guessing and preparing with confidence (Artifact #1).

In upper-division thermodynamics (CHEM 110A), my goal is to turn lecture exposure into usable problem-solving ability. Students can follow derivations but still struggle to start unfamiliar problems, especially when the "why" never became intuitive in lecture. My response is guided practice where we collectively as a class select an approach, state assumptions, check whether an answer makes sense, and interpret results. Tutorial Problem Set 5 provides a concrete example of how I use published data, so students practice extracting meaning from the real world of science (Artifact #3).

In advanced undergraduate/PhD-level physical chemistry (CHEM 123AB/223AB and CHEM 115AB/215AB), students often hesitate to ask questions because they do not want to look unprepared. I make question-asking casual and normal, and I devote time in discussion for students to attempt the problems on their own. This sets the expectation that students must try before solutions appear. Low-stakes quizzes and hands-on computer simulations reinforce the same message: progress comes from iteration, not from getting it right immediately. Quiz 3 illustrates an assessment designed to reward attempts and interpretation, including a targeted hint at a common stall point (Artifact #2). The weekly discussion forum I ran also supports this goal by making it easy to ask questions early and by allowing students to respond to each other in a low-pressure setting (Artifact #5).

Finally, I take seriously the reality of widely available AI tools. The teaching question is not whether students can generate output; it is whether students can explain and evaluate ideas. In CHEM 223A, my PhD advisor and I designed the course to keep learning anchored in class-time reasoning and revision, including structured engagement during class and a final project built during class time. Alongside that, the weekly forum helped keep instruction aligned with what students were actually struggling with.

My commitment to equitable teaching is personal. I grew up seeing education as the way out of poverty, and I still teach like that is true. For me, inclusion is not lowering expectations but rather ensuring adequate supports for each learner to achieve the desired outcome. It is designing an environment where students will attempt, ask questions, practice repeatedly, and become independent learners.

Artifact #1: Excerpts from Student Experiences of Teaching (SET) Reports

This exhibit consolidates Student Experiences of Teaching comments across lower-division labs (14BL/14CL), upper-division thermodynamics (110A), and graduate physical chemistry (115AB/215AB and 123A/223A). They demonstrate a sustained pattern of impact across years and distinct courses. The comments from students align with the award criteria: students describing approachability and comfort asking questions, clear guidance on how to begin difficult work, structured practice and review support, and instruction that clarifies lecture material while maintaining high expectations.

Lower-Division Instructional Chemistry Labs

22F CHEM 14BL LAB 1C

"Give this man a promotion … Tucker is literally the best. He made the class so fun for me by creating an awesome lab environment. He knows the material super well he is so nice and approachable and is such a fair grader. I have never had a bad lab experience with him … He serious is one of the best teachers I have had here or anywhere. 10/10"

"Tucker was absolutely amazing. He made class fun, he was really easy to talk to, and he knew what he was talking to at all times. By far one of the best TAs I have had at ucla. I really enjoyed the lab with him. His posted review for the midterm and final was amazing, it helped so much more than anything else."

22F CHEM 14BL LAB 1K

"Tucker is a great TA! He always addressed me and the other students by name, and was very open to questions. He clearly knows the material very well, and was able to guide me through concepts I was struggling with/confirm concepts I was unsure about. Tucker also held useful review sessions and resources outside of class, volunteering his time and energy to help us through preparing for the midterm and final. I think I would be very lost in this course if I didn't have such a supportive TA."

23W CHEM 14CL LAB 2A

"I loved having Tucker as my TA for such a difficult, convoluted class. I don't even have the words to express my gratitude. Every student in the room felt comfortable asking questions, expressing doubt, asking for help, asking for advice, and much much more. He made sure that every student was genuinely cared for. IT IS RARE! I have been here long enough with enough careless TAs to know that Tucker is something special … He answered emails within a reasonable period of time which is essential with fleeting deadlines. I have so much more to say but I do not have the words. Tucker is the best. I will miss this class because of him."

24S CHEM 14BL LAB 1C

"I am not very good at chemistry, but Tucker made me feel very comfortable in every lab section. I felt comfortable asking him any and all questions I had. I wasn't nervous to go to his office hours. I felt like he genuinely wanted me to do well which was refreshing for a stem course."

Upper-Division Physical Chemistry

23S CHEM 110A TUT 1AA

"I love Tucker's tutorial because he usually went over problem sets using the formulas we got in class. I often found myself being so lost in doing the homework just merely based on the lecture, so I would say that his tutorial and discussion really clarify the class content tremendously."

25S CHEM 110A DIS 2A

“Tucker is one of the best TA's I've had at UCLA. He is so knowledgeable about our content and does an incredible job expanding on what our professor taught us in lecture. He always comes to discussion with very organized notes and a plan to get through the material in a pace that's comprehensible and effective. He's very open with us about the grading timelines and always encourages us to ask for help. Thermodynamics is not meant to be an easy course, but both Tucker and Professor Eric make it one of the most interesting and intuitive experiences I've had at this school.”

Graduate-Level Physical Chemistry

23F CHEM C215A DIS 1A

“Tucker is a fantastic TA. He is genuinely one of the best TAs I have ever had. Tucker is fantastic at helping us digest the difficult course material and providing guidance on how to even begin the homework. I have really appreciated having him as a resource for this class. He is extremely helpful in his discussions and also over email, something that I have appreciated as I have conflicts during his office hours.”

“Tucker was a fantastic TA! I enjoy how he managed to simplify really complex topics covered in lecture and give another perspective - this was especially helpful when trying to understand the homework questions!”

24W CHEM C215B DIS 1A

“Tucker was a fantastic TA who went above and beyond both quarters of teaching Quantum Mechanics, despite his hours being arbitrarily cut in half for a course that already demands too much of the TA. He is incredibly knowledgeable about QM and explained things in many different ways for students to understand. He made sure that all students, no matter how much they might be struggling, could keep up with the course material and homeworks and succeed in the course.”

25F CHEM C123A DIS 1A

“I think Tucker is probably the strongest TA I have ever had at UCLA. He is excellent at explaining difficult concepts, very confident in the material such that he can answer all of our questions, and hits the right balance of giving students the hints they need to succeed while making sure we are challenged and have to work hard to earn our grades … He also individually answers questions posted by each student in a weekly discussion forum, frequently citing our lecture notes or textbooks so students can refer to materials to get the clarification they need. It is rare to find someone has all three: a mastery of the content, mastery of teaching, and a willingness to go above and beyond the expectations of a TA, but Tucker always checks all three boxes. I am very grateful to have had him as my TA and am very excited to continue taking the second class in this series with him as my TA.”

25F CHEM C223A DIS 1A

“Tucker did a great job of identifying concepts that the class was struggling to understand in the lecture and going over them with great clarity. He does an amazing job at understanding what students are struggling with and organizing the discussion to aid these problems.”

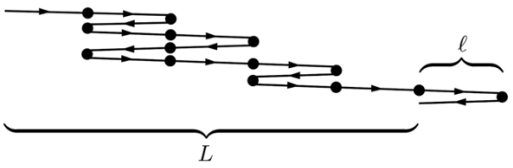
Artifact #2: Quiz from CHEM 123A/223A (Fall 2025)

This quiz is intentionally low stakes, being worth only 1% of the overall course grade. The goal is to keep students attempting and to reward reasoning, not just a clean final answer. Part (b) is a common place students stall, so I scaffold with a targeted hint, without doing the thinking for them. The last part forces the point: students must explain why the model predicts what it predicts, not only box a mathematical formula. This is one of five quizzes across the quarter, and I use them as structured practice, so students build the habit of trying, checking themselves, and interpreting results before anything high stakes.

F25 CHEM 123A/223A Quiz 3 Thursday, October 16

Name: _____ **UID:** _____

A simple model for a rubber-band is a one-dimensional chain with N segments each of length l. Each segment can point either left or right. The total length L of the rubber band is the net displacement from the beginning of the first segment to the end of the last (see below) and can be written as: $L = l(2N_R - N)$, where N_R is the number of segments pointing right.



a) Use Stirling's approximation to show that the entropy is given by:

$$S \approx k_B[N \ln N - N_R \ln N_R - (N - N_R)\ln(N - N_R)]$$

Part A is a standard problem that students have encountered several times before taking this quiz.

b) The thermodynamic identity $F = -T\left(\frac{\partial S}{\partial L}\right)_U$ can be worked out to give the tension force:

$$F = \frac{k_B T}{2l} \ln \frac{1 + (L/Nl)}{1 - (L/Nl)}$$

When $L \ll Nl$, show that the tension force follows Hooke's law $F = kL$. Find k in terms of k_B, T, N, l.

Hint: Use the series expansion $\ln \frac{1+x}{1-x} \approx 2x + \frac{2}{3}x^2 + \frac{2}{5}x^5 + \cdots$

Part B requires scaffolding. Rather than asking the students to do extra math to obtain "F", I provide the force expression and ask them instead to show that "F" satisfies a familiar law of physics.

c) Use your result from (b) to explain why the rubber band contracts when heated at fixed tension F.

Part C is where students extract meaning from the statistical model. They can reason, from their results from (a)/(b), why a rubber band shrinks when heated up.

Artifact #3: Tutorial Problem Set for CHEM 110A (Spring 2023)

This tutorial set is designed as guided practice to help students get in the routine of solving different flavors of thermodynamics problems. Students get roughly 15-20 minutes to work in pairs first so they must make an honest attempt before seeing a solution. Then I go through everything on the board step-by-step and we pause often for questions. The goal is to make the "first move" in each problem feel learnable, and to build the habit of trying, checking, and interpreting results. This ensures students don't find out they were lost only when the homework is due, or an exam is coming up.

Q1 extends what we just learned in class to a slightly more complicated scenario. The hint points students toward the right idea so they don't freeze at the start.

110A-1 S23 Tutorial 5

1. The internal energy, U, and equation of state, $P(T,V)$, for a van der Waals gas are written below:

$$U = \frac{3}{2}nRT - \frac{an^2}{V}$$

$$P(T,V) = \frac{nRT}{V-nb} - \frac{an^2}{V^2}$$

Derive an expression for the change in entropy, ΔS, of a van der Waals gas undergoing a transformation $(T_1, V_1) \rightarrow (T_2, V_2)$, provided that no phase changes or chemical reactions occur in the system.

Hint: You'll need the following Maxwell relation: $\left(\frac{\partial S}{\partial V}\right)_T = \left(\frac{\partial P}{\partial T}\right)_V$

2. (Engel/Reid P5.7)

Using the differential form of $S = S(T,P)$ and the following tabulated values for $H_2O(l)$:

$$dS = \frac{C_P}{T}dT - V\alpha dP$$

$$C_{P,m} = 75.3\ \text{J mol}^{-1}\text{K}^{-1}, \alpha = 2.04 \times 10^{-4}\ \text{K}^{-1}, \rho = 998\ \text{kg m}^{-3}$$

Calculate the temperature decrease that occurs when 1.75 moles of liquid water at 298 K and 1475 bar are brought to a final pressure of 1.00 bar in a reversible adiabatic process.

Q2 is a straightforward textbook-style problem that aligns with the homework. It's here to build confidence on a core skill, with no surprises.

Q3 uses real experimental data to calculate something we just learned in class. It's a stretch because it requires a math technique called "numerical integration," but I guide that part so students can focus on meaning and interpretation.

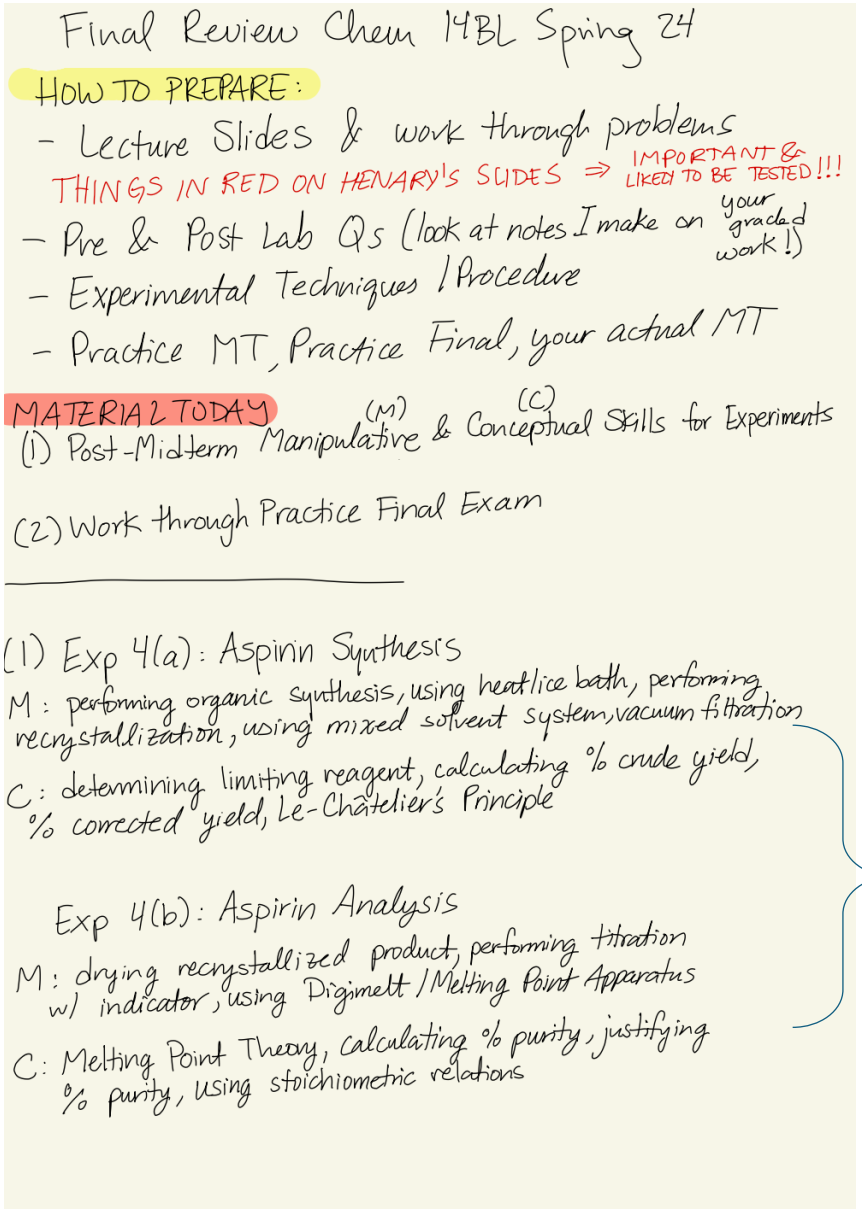
3. Given that $S_m^\circ = 29.79\ \frac{\text{J}}{\text{mol K}}$ for bismuth at 100 K and the following tabulated heat capacity data (D.G. Archer, *J. Chem. Eng. Data* **40**, 1015 (1995)), determine the standard molar entropy of bismuth at 200 K.

T (K)	100	120	140	150	160	180	200
$C_{P,m}$ $\left(\frac{\text{J}}{\text{mol K}}\right)$	23.00	23.74	24.25	24.44	24.61	24.89	25.11

Artifact #4: Final Exam Review Notes for CHEM 14BL (Spring 2024)

This review sheet is about transparency. Lab final exams are high stress because students do not always know what preparation should look like, especially with uneven lab experience coming in. I spell out how to prepare and map the required skills to each experiment so students can study efficiently instead of guessing. Note: the worked practice final solutions are excluded here (over 20 pages); I worked them through with students on the board.

This is the checklist I give students, so exam preparation is clear. They know what to review so there are no doubts for what is expected of them.



Final Review Chem 14BL Spring 24

HOW TO PREPARE:

- Lecture Slides & work through problems
  THINGS IN RED ON HENARY'S SLIDES ⇒ IMPORTANT & LIKELY TO BE TESTED!!!
- Pre & Post Lab Qs (look at notes I make on your graded work!)
- Experimental Techniques / Procedure
- Practice MT, Practice Final, your actual MT

MATERIAL TODAY

(1) Post-Midterm Manipulative (M) & Conceptual (C) Skills for Experiments

(2) Work through Practice Final Exam

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(1) Exp 4(a): Aspirin Synthesis

M: performing organic synthesis, using heat/ice bath, performing recrystallization, using mixed solvent system, vacuum filtration

C: determining limiting reagent, calculating % crude yield, % corrected yield, Le-Châtelier's Principle

Exp 4(b): Aspirin Analysis

M: drying recrystallized product, performing titration w/ indicator, using Digimelt / Melting Point Apparatus

C: Melting Point Theory, calculating % purity, justifying % purity, using stoichiometric relations

I separate what students *do* (hands-on manipulative skills using lab equipment) from what they must be able to *explain* (conceptual and quantitative reasoning skills).

Exp. 6: Titration

M: pH meter / electrode, Vol. buret (Pipet/flask), Run a titration

C: Equivalence Point, 1/2 Eq. Point, Henderson Hasselbach Eqn, ICE Tables, Eq. Dissociation Expressions K_a, K_b

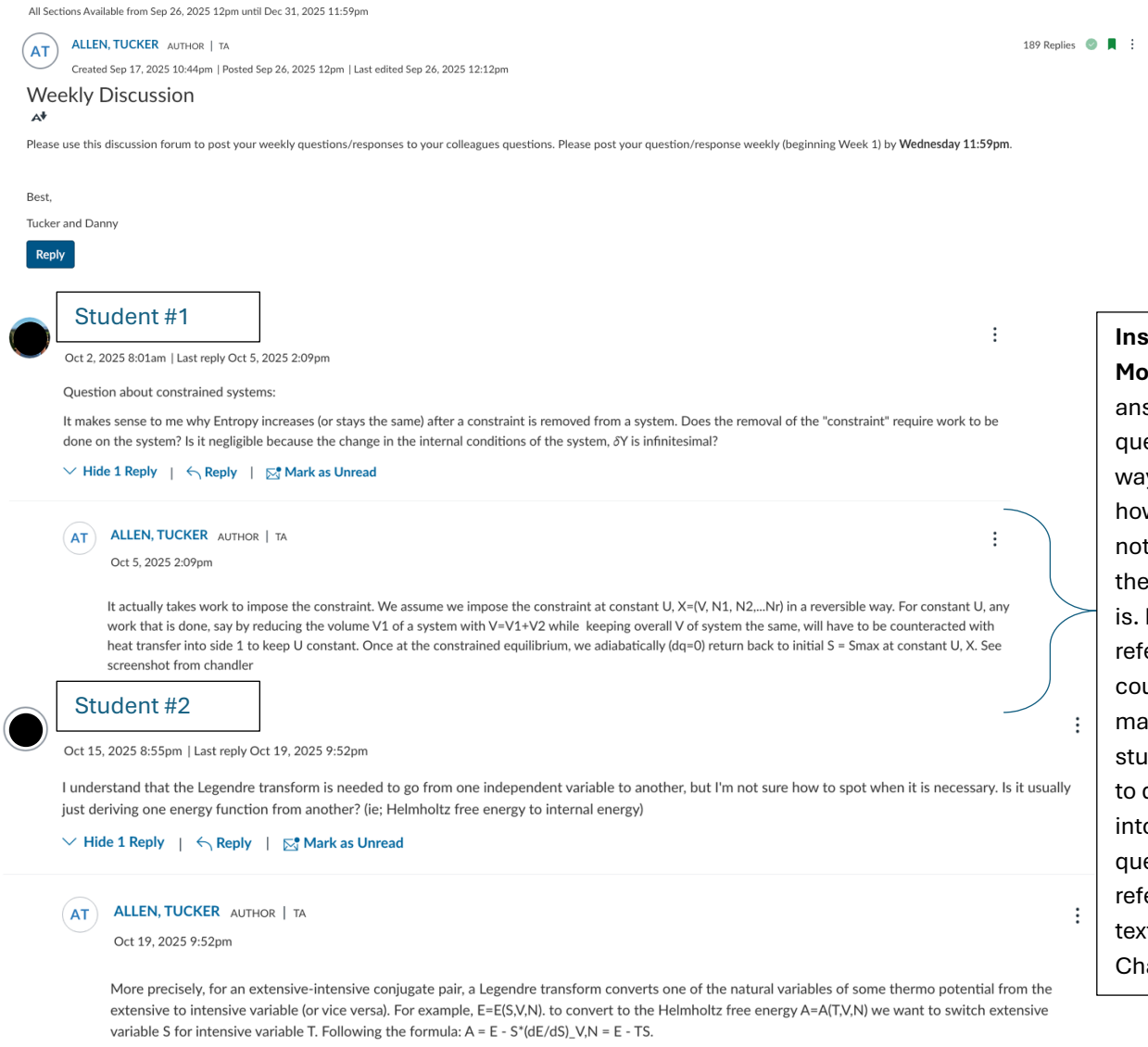
Exp 5: Kinetics

M: Using Spectrophotometer, Serial Dilutions, Performing time-dependent reaction

C: Constructing Beer's Law Calibration Curve, Using Spectrophotometric Data to construct Integrated Rate Law Plots, determining the order of reactants & overall order of reaction

Artifact #5: BruinLearn Discussion Forum for CHEM 123A/223A (Fall 2025)

This weekly forum was meant to make asking questions the norm. Students posted lecture questions each week and responded to classmates. I stayed active in the thread to clarify, correct, and push explanations forward, and I used what showed up there to decide what we needed to spend time on in the next discussion. It also gave students a low-pressure place to ask something the moment they were confused instead of sitting with it until next lecture or office hour.



Instructor Moderation: I answer questions in a way that models how to think, not just what the final answer is. I try to also reference course materials if the students want to dive further into the question – here referencing our textbook by Chandler.

Student #3

Nov 6, 2025 11:49pm | Last reply Nov 9, 2025 5:27pm

I am a little confused on the how the use of periodic boundary conditions got us the new 1D ising model partition function since it seems like it was never derived. How would we go from the earlier partition function to the PBC part function? Also i know a PBC would affect a 3x3 matrix but would it have any effect on a 2x2 matrix or would it look the same at the open boundary conditions? Also what is a PBC in the physical context of a system represented by the Ising model?

Hide 1 Reply | Reply | Mark as Unread

AT **ALLEN, TUCKER** AUTHOR | TA

Nov 9, 2025 5:27pm

The spin–spin term only includes nearest neighbors, so the issue is how to handle the spins at the ends of the chain. With periodic boundary conditions, we wrap the chain around so S1 and SN are neighbors, giving every spin two neighbors. In the transfer matrix form, this just means we take Tr(D^N) to connect the ends. Physically, it models a looped or repeating system with no edges. Anytime you simulate a periodic system you assume it is infinitely repeating, that is why we need to take N to infinity to finish the derivation of Q in 1D.

Students teaching each other: This is the goal of the forum. Students use the forum to try an explanation publicly, get corrected or refined by a classmate, and then move on with a better mental model. It keeps the learning student-centered and makes it easier for quieter students to participate.

Student #4

Oct 22, 2025 7:08pm | Last reply Oct 27, 2025 10:37am

For the vibrational component of energy for a diatomic gas, how does the series (h_bar)w/2 + 3(h_bar)w/2 + 5(h_bar)w/2 + ... approximate to (h_bar)w/2 + (h_bar)wn?

Hide 2 Replies | Reply | Mark as Unread

Student #5

Oct 22, 2025 8:24pm | Last edited Oct 22, 2025 8:25pm

View History

the series comes from (h_bar)w/2 + (h_bar)wn=hbar*w*(n+1/2) rather than the other way around. the series is just the expanded sum of the energy levels of the quantum harmonic oscillator which we ge from solving the shrodinger eq.

Reply | Mark as Unread

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name: Dana Roelofs

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

Tucker was my Teaching Assistant for Chemistry 223A/123A, a graduate level dual enrollment class, Advanced Thermodynamics and Statistical Mechanics with Laboratory.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Tucker was able to inspire students in class by demonstrating relevant applications of the material we were learning to research or other endeavors outside the classroom. Whether that be a final project that allowed us to investigate how the Ising model and Monte Carlo simulations explain magnetism in materials or homework questions calculating the partition function of DNA. He made the material feel important to learn and inspired students to engage with it in class, lab, through the homework exercises and during office hours. Tucker challenged us when it came to solving problems on our own, he would always help us with a place to start but provide the necessary room for students to get their as independently as possible. For example, during office hours and discussion he would help you set up the problem and provide hints as necessary allowing for students to collaborate and learn without being completely lost.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Tucker is unique in the way he was able to effectively present the material along with the expectations for the course. In discussion he broke down concepts into their most basic components and explained each, only after establishing a base understanding would he go into the details of how to calculate specific values and examples. He would also always pick out the key concepts and equations for us to note making it easier to follow what content was central to the class. He did a particularly great job for the midterm and final reviews giving very clear overviews of the different ensembles including when you use each, explained the different Ising model dimensions and redid important derivations. Another central part of learning is understanding what is expected of students in a course, he was always clear on what material you need to know for quizzes and exams allowing students to prepare well for exams even if they were challenging.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

One additional reason Tucker is an outstanding candidate is because he made readily himself available to students, whether that be answering questions in lecture or arranging extra office hours before an exam. As a student you could also tell that he had a great mastery of the material and was able to answer questions outside of the scope of the class when asked. Overall, Tucker worked with a wide range of students supporting their learning and success throughout the quarter!

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Feb 5th, 2026

UCLA Distinguished TA Award Selection Committee
Re: Nomination of Tucker Allen for outstanding TA award

Dear Selection Committee,

I write this letter to express my enthusiastic recommendation for **Tucker Allen** for one of the UCLA outstanding TA awards. Tucker was my TA for two quarters in my Chem 115A/B 215A/B classes during the '23-'24 academic year, and did a truly outstanding job. The classes are the required graduate quantum mechanics sequence, which most students say are the most abstract and mathematically sophisticated courses they've ever encountered in their careers. This means that as TA, Tucker not only had to have complete mastery of the course materials, but also had to be able to explain the abstract concepts and mathematical derivations to the students in a way that could clarify any confusion they have. Tucker truly excelled at this, as his TA evaluations for the course clearly showed.

In addition to his prowess in discussion section and office hours, Tucker also had to grade the 20+ pages of homework the students turn in every week (at least during the 'A' course, see below), which he did quickly and efficiently, as well as grade both the midterm and the final. I was particularly impressed with the rubric Tucker put together while grading, keeping track of every error that every student made and the number of points deducted, so that there were no issues with students asking for regrades or different amounts of partial credit, making this one of the smoothest times that I've ever taught these courses in terms of grade assignments.

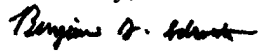
Next, I should point out that on short notice (literally the week before winter break), Tucker was informed that his TA position for the 'B' course was being cut to 25% time. This meant that Tucker couldn't attend my lectures and had to cut his office hours in order to avoid going over 10 hrs/week with all of the grading he needed to do. I helped pick up some of his office hours and I also had to reduce my homework to every other week in order to ensure that Tucker did not exceed the cut TA appointment hours. Despite all this, Tucker managed to stay completely on top of the course material, and other than the reduced office hours, the students in the course were largely unaware of the fact that Tucker was only a part-time TA, which is a real testament to Tucker's teaching (and time-management) skills.

Finally, one of the students in the 'B' class somehow got a hold of the solutions to my problem sets (I'm still trying to determine how this happened), and Tucker noticed that the student's homework contained information from the solutions that were not actually required in the problem

sets (i.e. the student's homework included the 'extra' things I put in the solutions for 'color'). Tucker's careful detective work allowed me to file an academic dishonesty case against this student with the Dean of Students' office. I'm extremely impressed that despite his limited time, Tucker was able to pick up on the fact that this student was cheating, and I'm grateful for his efforts.

Overall, my understanding is that Tucker was also an outstanding TA in the courses he taught this past year, and based on my own personal experience with him these previous year, I certainly believe it. For all of these reasons, I strongly urge you to consider Tucker for one of the UCLA outstanding TA awards.

Sincerely,



Benjamin J. Schwartz
Distinguished Professor of Physical Chemistry
Dept. of Chem. & Biochem., UCLA